



ON THE WRITE LINE

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STORIES

IPL OWNERS NEED TO START GETTING TOUGH AND DROP OVERSEAS PLAYERS, WHO DECIDE TO COME WHENEVER THEY WANT

We are already hearing about some players who will not be available for a variety of reasons, **none of which were communicated** before they were selected by the franchise.

The Sportstar Aces Awards evening was, as always, an evening to remember. It is such an incredible feeling to be in a room with India's champion athletes, who have brought medals and glory to the country. That the President of the Indian Olympic Association, the incomparable PT Usha, graced the function and also spoke tells you how highly regarded the event is.

Not only was there a celebration of the champions and winners of today and the hopes of the future, but there was also plenty of nostalgia in the air with the felicitation of Mary Kom, Mirabai Chanu, M. D. Valsamma, Nari Contractor, and Australian fast-bowling legend Glenn McGrath, alongside the presence of former women cricketers Chanderkanta Kaul, Pramila Bhat, Sudha Shah, Purnima Rau, Diana Edulji, Shubhangi Kulkarni, Nilima Joglekar, Sandhya Agarwal, Anju Jain, and Jhulan Goswami.

The many sponsors, institutions, and States that generously and selflessly contribute were also there to show their solidarity with Indian

sport. It truly was an evening to cherish, one that warms the cockles of the heart. No praise is too high for The Hindu Group, which has, over decades, showcased the world of sport through its sports pages and through this magazine, especially at a time when reading does not quite seem to be the favoured pastime of so many.

Over the next couple of months, cricket fans will be consumed by the best T20 league in the world, the Indian Premier League. **With the Royal Challengers Bengaluru winning their first title last year after an 18-year wait, will this year also see a first-time winner like Punjab or Delhi?** Of the eight original franchises, these two are now the only ones left without the coveted trophy and will be going all guns (or should it be missiles and drones?) blazing to get their hands on the prize. There will also be the perennial naysayers trying to bring down one of the great sporting properties in the world and the country's pride, with their views and articles suggesting lower ad revenues, lower viewership, lower crowds, and so on.

With a tight season that also had the ICC